The speech came as a bombshell. The prime minister condemned it at the next weekly cabinet meeting, and asked Ya'alon to demand an apology from Golan, thought to be a future contender for army chief. Ya'alon refused, and then went one step further, encouraging other officers to follow Golan's lead. "I call on you, the commanders of the IDF, to say what is in your heart," he said the following week at an Independence Day celebration. He urged them to follow their "moral compass", not to act "according to which way the winds are blowing."

It would be his farewell address. Netanyahu summoned him for a dressing-down on Sunday. On Wednesday he offered the defense ministry to Lieberman, an ultra-nationalist who had spent the previous year attacking him from the opposition. At 9 am on Friday, Ya'alon announced his resignation in a tweet, saying he had "lost confidence" in the prime minister.

A former commando and army chief, Ya'alon is a soft-spoken and uncharismatic politician, often visibly uncomfortable with the trappings of his new profession. With his bald pate and penchant for short-sleeved Oxfords, he looks more like a retiree at a Sizzler in Florida than a hardened veteran. But the press conference he gave at the defense ministry on 20 May, hours after he announced his departure, was positively scathing. "Unfortunately, Israel and the Likud party were taken over by extremist and dangerous elements," he said. "This is not the Likud party I joined."

It was a dramatic change, not only for Ya'alon, but for Israel. Lieberman is a hawkish politician who has suggested toppling the Palestinian Authority, beheading "disloyal" citizens with axes, and bombing the Aswan High Dam in Egypt. Benny Begin, a Likud lawmaker and the son of the party's first prime minister, called the appointment "delusional". Moshe Arens, a three-time defense minister and Likud stalwart, called it a "turning point" in Israel's political history.[4]

Palestinians and Israelis, like people trapped in an unhappy marriage, can be incisive observers of each other's flaws. A few weeks after the shooting, I met in Gaza with Bassem Naim, a Hamas official and an adviser to former prime minister Ismail Haniyeh. He reminisced about the defense minister's past as an elite army commando: Ya'alon had taken part in the 1988 raid that killed Khalil al-Wazir, a leading Palestinian militant. Wazir, who went by the *nom de guerre* Abu Jihad, was shot dead in front of his wife and children at his home in Tunis.